

Did the Xiong-nu Speak a Yeniseian Language?¹

by

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Until the early 1960s it was generally assumed that the Xiong-nu were ancestors of either Turks or other Altaic peoples (such as Mongols or Tunguses). Several scholars also came up with proposals that they represented a mixture of these peoples (for the detailed overview of the bibliography see Doerfer 1973). In 1962, however, Pulleyblank proposed a new theory, connecting the Xiong-nu language with the Yeniseian family of Central Siberia (Pulleyblank 1962).²

The Yeniseian family consists of the Ket language, which is still spoken today, but is lingering on the brink of extinction, and several extinct languages: Yug, Kott, Assan, Arin, and Pumpokol. Our knowledge of Assan, Arin, and Pumpokol is limited mostly to word lists, as these languages became extinct in 18th century. The Kott and Yug languages are somewhat better known, especially the latter, as Kott became extinct in the later part of 19th century, and Yug only recently. Pulleyblank's hypothesis was enthusiastically embraced by some scholars, e.g. Yakhontov 1986, and energetically rejected by others (Doerfer 1973).

The Xiong-nu language is known to us only through the about hundred fifty glosses and possibly one very short text consisting of just two lines in the Chinese transcription. All previous attempts to identify the Xiong-nu language with one or the other

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2 The first suggestion that the Xiong-nu language may belong to Yeniseian family belongs to Ligeti who demonstrated that Xiong-nu (more exactly Hu) *sak-dak "shoe" is reminiscent of Ket *sagdi* "id." (1950), however, it was Pulleyblank who presented the credible evidence first that also included examples from basic vocabulary.